Dongria Kondh

Life in Niyamgiri



Ahimanikya Satapathy

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Twelve connected chapters drawn from published research and attributed reporting.

Photographs document the subjects identified in their credits. Interpretive illustrations depict imagined scenes.

Picture credits and source notes appear at the back.

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Contents

Author's note · 4

Before we begin · 6

Locating Niyamgiri · 7

Dongria life in Niyamgiri · 8

Niyamgiri: cultivation and village decisions · 13

Homes and the work of repair in Niyamgiri · 18

Keeping seeds in circulation in Niyamgiri · 23

Forest foods and home gardens in Rayagada · 28

From Niyamgiri harvests to market · 33

Kapadaganda — the embroidered cloth of Niyamgiri · 38

Dongria ornaments in use · 46

Kotpad and Kapadaganda through their makers · 50

Learning and belonging in Niyamgiri · 54

Kuvi and the Jatapu script · 59

Songs and singers in Dongria life · 66

Looking again · 70

Words in this book · 71

Notes & sources · 74

Pictures & credits · 82

A shawl, and the questions it opened

This book began at a dinner table.

At a dinner party with friends, I noticed the cloth used for the table mats and hand towels. My host also had shawls for sale, and I bought one. I fell in love with it. Perhaps I had seen something like it before, but I had never paused to understand where it came from or whose work I was looking at.

I was already working on Project Odisha, exploring the places, culture and literature of Odisha. This encounter gave that work a personal direction. I wanted to learn about the people behind the cloth, the place they called home and the lives around its making.

The reading took me far beyond the shawl. Information was scattered across reports, studies and individual accounts. Over the following weeks, I read and brought these stories together, trying to keep people at the centre: those who grow food, keep seeds, embroider, teach, learn and sing.

My delight in the designs found other forms, too. I made a bag inspired by them and had ten T-shirts printed. Those were my own adaptations. As my curiosity grew, I wanted to understand more of the lives and work from which that inspiration came.

I felt embarrassed by how little I had known about this part of Odisha. That feeling soon became a reason to keep learning. What had first caught my eye as a beautiful garment had opened questions about skill, livelihood, land, memory and belonging.

I have not yet visited Niyamgiri. This first book grows from weeks of reading and research; the visit, and the listening I hope to do there, still lie ahead. There is much I do not yet know.

I hope these pages bring you insight and some of the joy this discovery has brought me. I hope, too, that when you look at a cloth, you pause a little longer with the people whose work gives it life.

For me, this is a beginning.

Ahimanikya Satapathy

Before we begin

“He created fruit in the hills, grains in the plains,”

— Dambu Praska, Dongria Kondh singer. English rendering published by Living Farms, 2009.

In his song of Niyam Raja, Praska names the food that sustains life. We begin with the hills and the people who make their homes there, then follow the work of growing food and taking a harvest to market. Cloth and ornaments bring makers and wearers into the story. Students, teachers and singers carry us towards questions of language, memory and what one generation shares with another. Each account belongs to particular people, places and years.

This book brings together published research and attributed reporting. It cannot supply every voice or resolve every uncertainty. The notes keep those limits visible. Photographs and imagined illustrations offer different kinds of pause; the picture notes at the back identify each one.

Read slowly enough to notice who is speaking, who is doing the work and who is making the decision. Let the names stay with the cloth, the crop and the song.

Living Farms, GRAIN, 26 July 2009; translator unnamed.

Locating Niyamgiri

Odisha, India



Odisha

The outlined area locates the regional view below.

State outline: Natural Earth. Regional positions: cited sources.

Kalahandi district

Niyamgiri hills

approximate regional position

N

Rayagada district

- Rayagada town

Niyamgiri lies in southwestern Odisha, across parts of Kalahandi and Rayagada districts. This schematic locator shows the region's position, not hill boundaries, village locations or travel routes.

Sources: Rayagada Forest Division working plan, §1.2.2; Niyamgiri field study, surveyed sites; Rayagada Municipality, location; Rayagada District Profile, §2.1; Natural Earth state outline (public domain).

CHAPTER / 01

Dongria life in Niyamgiri



In Gandili, Singari Jakesika described a change in what her household grew and what she ate. Her husband had increased horticulture to earn more income; less land went to millets, and her own consumption of millet declined as she increasingly ate subsidised rice. Her account appears in Deepanwita Gita Niyogi's November 2022 reporting.[4]

That decision brings the landscape close to home. Land can provide food and income, but the balance between them depends partly on who makes the choices. This book follows those choices through cultivation, cloth, homes, learning and song.

Niyamgiri and its households

The Niyamgiri landscape extends across Rayagada and Kalahandi. This book uses Dongria; some sources use the spellings Dongariya or Dongaria. The Odisha State Tribal Museum uses "Dongria Kandha" and locates settlements in the ranges across Bissamcuttack, Kalyansingpur and Muniguda blocks of Rayagada.[2,4]

The museum describes horticulture and cultivation on hill slopes, and lists Dongria Kandha among Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups, commonly abbreviated as PVTGs. That administrative category helps identify the scope of government records; it cannot describe a household's ambitions or everyday life on its own.[2]

Food, income and who decides

Singari's account puts the effects of a crop choice within the household. In the same 2022 reporting, Palari of Kadraguma wanted greater emphasis on millets and connected crop choices with women having more authority over land.[4]

Their views belong to particular women and villages. They draw attention to the work and preferences within a family, as well as the prices available outside it.

Cultivating with other people

Anthropologist Sujatarani Dandapat's study, based on 2017–18 fieldwork centred on Kurli, describes finger millet, pulses, sesame and tubers among food crops, alongside pineapple, banana and other crops grown for sale.[1]

Her account also follows cooperation between households. Neighbours and relatives helped families facing illness or a shortage of workers, and the household receiving help provided meals. Horticultural work relied more on family members. Food and labour therefore connected households as well as sustaining them.[1]

Seed keeping follows another relationship between growers: obtaining, planting and returning seed. Harvests and markets continues the story through selling days, buyers and the costs of reaching them.

Learning in familiar words

Knowledge also passes through shared work. In Kanak Rajadhyaksha's November 2017 interviews, women described learning embroidery from paternal aunts.[5] The account of Kapadaganda and its makers follows those relationships; Learning and belonging turns to students and teachers.

Language needs the same attention to particular speakers. The museum lists both Kui and Kuvi in its community profile. The Central Institute of Indian Languages maintains separate entries for the related languages and describes Kuvi as a Dravidian language spoken in Odisha and Andhra Pradesh, with writing in the Odia script.[2,3] The language of a song or a crop name cannot be settled by a community label alone.

From a programme to a household

A January 2026 parliamentary reply describes PM JANMAN support covering housing, water, education, healthcare and connectivity. Its Rayagada annex combines Dongria Kondh with other PVTGs; those district totals do not identify Dongria-only outcomes.[6]

The account of homes and repair follows what such totals leave open: whether a house shelters its residents and whether they can maintain it. Singari and Palari's accounts ask a related question of the fields—what reaches the household, and who has a say? The next account follows land from household cultivation to the village assemblies that spoke about its future.

CHAPTER / 02

Niyamgiri: cultivation and village decisions



Suresh Wadaka explained a slope through the roots of its crops. In an undated study commissioned by Odisha's Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes Research and Training Institute, he described how shallow and deeper root systems worked differently against soil loss. Their spread and depth mattered when deciding what to plant together.[1]

The Foundation for Ecological Security's researchers used interviews and walks in selected villages around Chatikona. Wadaka's explanation offers one way of understanding cultivated land from the work done upon it; the study records village differences, language barriers and gaps in its seasonal observations.[1]

A landscape that feeds households

In 2017–18 fieldwork centred on Kurli, Sujatarani Dandapat described food crops and commercial horticulture sharing the farming landscape, sometimes the same plot. Finger millet, pulses and tubers appeared alongside pineapple, banana and turmeric.[2]

Singari Jakesika and Palari's later accounts bring household choices into that picture: how much land to give to millets, how to earn income and who has authority to decide.[3] Those accounts describe different people and years from the village meetings of 2013. They help us see why land has everyday importance, without supplying the participants' reasons for their votes.

Asking the villages

On 18 April 2013, the Supreme Court directed village assemblies, or Gram Sabhas, to examine individual, community, cultural and religious claims in the Niyamgiri case. They were to consider whether the proposed mining would affect those rights, including worship associated with Niyam-Raja and the deity's abode.[4]

A judicial officer of district-judge rank was to observe and certify the proceedings. The assemblies' decisions would inform the Ministry's final decision on Stage II forest clearance. These were distinct responsibilities; the judgment separately addressed alleged violations at the Lanjigarh refinery.[4]

What people asked to have recorded

At Serkapadi on 18 July 2013, Dongria Kondh participants rejected mining. Sandip Das's report the following day connected the resolution with worship of Niyam Raja and identified district judge Sarat Chandra Mishra as observer. Contemporary newspapers give different attendance figures, retained in the source note.[7]

Kesarpadi's assembly followed on 22 July and also rejected mining. *The New Indian Express* reported that 33 of the village's 36 voters attended, attributing that figure to district collector Sashi Bhusan Padhi.[8]

In *Down To Earth*'s account, Dondu Kutruka asked officials to record the villagers' statements accurately and read them back. Residents insisted that their claims to the wider Niyamgiri landscape appear in the resolution before they signed. The report also identifies Suku Kutruka as the village forest rights committee president; he connected his opposition to mining with millet-growing slopes and forests shared with wildlife.[9]

What the record recognised—and how far that recognition extended—mattered alongside the vote itself. These are the reporter's accounts of their interventions, not a new transcription of the meeting.

Twelve village decisions

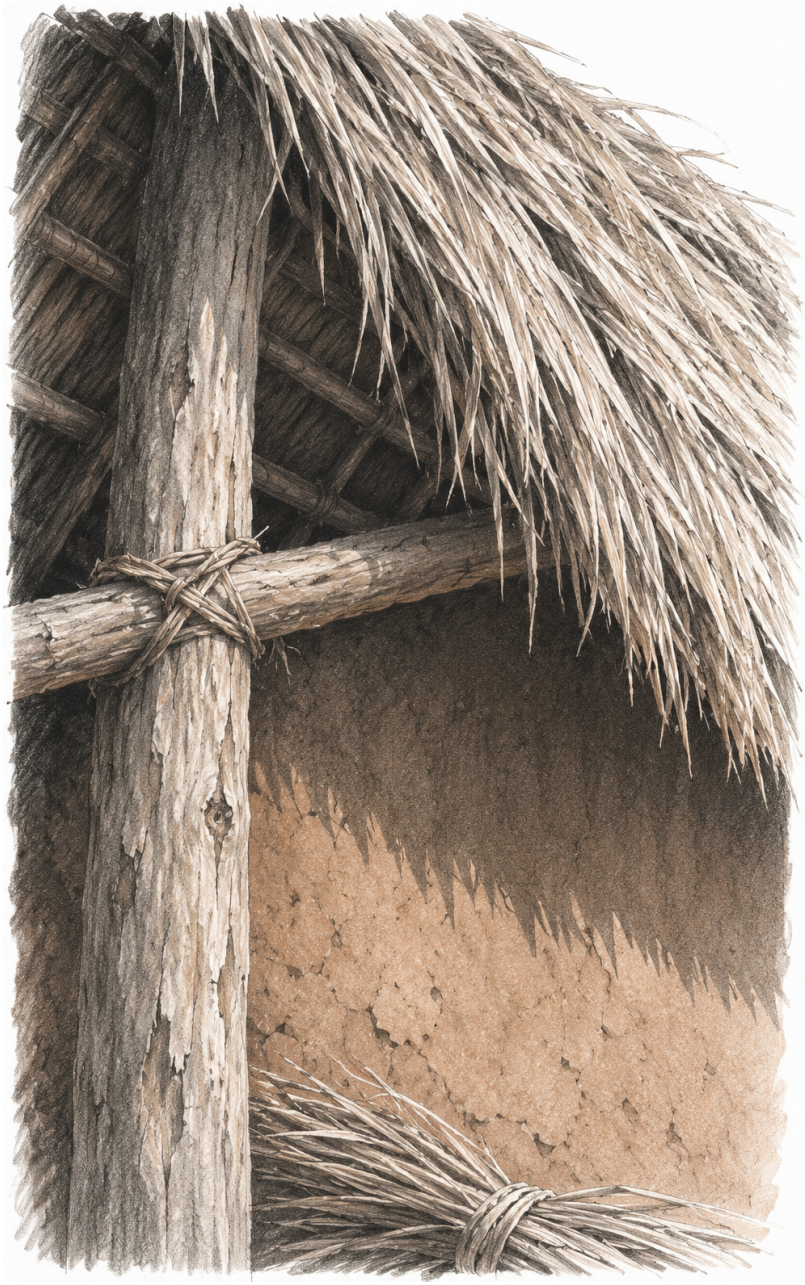
The Xaxa Committee's 2014 report records twelve assemblies held between 18 July and 19 August 2013 in hamlets selected by the state as likely to be affected. All twelve rejected the proposed mining. The committee drew on English translations of resolutions supplied by the state.[5]

A parliamentary answer in May 2015 records the same outcome, with seven villages in Rayagada and five in Kalahandi.[6] These are decisions by particular village assemblies, not a count of every settlement or individual in Niyamgiri. The historical record does not establish current permissions or a permanent ban.

Wadaka's explanation of roots and the assemblies' insistence on recording their claims concern different ways of knowing and speaking for land. People cultivate within this landscape, worship within it and argue about its future. The story now turns to their homes, and the work of keeping a household sheltered.

CHAPTER / 03

Homes and the work of repair in Niyamgiri



Mana Manjhi feared losing her roof in wind and heavy rain. In a UNDP account displayed with an August 2022 date, the Dongria Kondh farmer said support to build a pucca house had brought relief: she felt more confident that she and her grandson would have shelter during a storm.[1]

The value she described was practical: shelter for two people when the weather changed. Keeping a home habitable also involves repairs, money and access to help.

Building for the weather

In their July 2016 study of Niyamgiri, Meenal Tatpati, Ashish Kothari and Rashi Mishra described earthen houses arranged in parallel rows, with wooden posts and steeply sloping thatched roofs. They related the low-reaching roofs to protection from wind and rain.[2]

The researchers describe a particular building form; Mana speaks about her own home. Neither account settles how every thatched house performs.

The young men interviewed also wanted lighting at home and in village streets as kerosene became more expensive. They favoured solar power, explaining their concerns about wires in dense forest and the roads needed to bring in electricity poles.[2] Their preference joined an interest in useful services with concerns about how those services would reach them.

Repair before the rains

Income from forest produce could help cover repairs before the rains. Abhijit Mohanty's June 2020 report described households using these sales to pay for pre-monsoon repairs, livestock and farm inputs. Shyam Wadaka of Khajuri described being unable to reach Chatikana market or find buyers during lockdown.[3]

The report connects seasonal sales with maintenance costs, but does not say whether repairs to Wadaka's own home were delayed.

When a roof needs replacing

An October 2022 OdishaBytes report raised a different concern: the deterioration of roofs on houses built through earlier government assistance. It described households seeking help with repair or replacement and reported obstacles to obtaining further support. Minister Jagannath Saraka said the relevant department had been informed and that the problems would be addressed.[4]

No affected household was named, and the report recorded an assurance rather than completed repairs.

Houses counted and homes maintained

The scale of a housing programme is easier to count than the condition of a particular home. A January 2026 parliamentary reply reported 7,702 houses sanctioned and 6,004 completed under PM JANMAN in Rayagada, combining Dongria Kondh with other PVTGs. It does not identify Dongria-only recipients or connect the totals to the households discussed in 2022.[5]

Cloth designs on house walls

House walls also became part of a public effort to promote Dongria art. In September 2023, *OdishaBytes* reported a Special Development Council initiative to decorate homes with Kapdaganda designs in villages including Khambesi, Khajuri and Kurli. The report connected these designs with forms used on shrine walls and embroidered cloth.[6]

Sindhe Wadeka, identified as president of the Niyamgiri Dongria Kondh Weavers Association, welcomed the promotion of the community's art and associated it with belonging in *The Times of India*'s account later that month. Rayagada collector Swadha Dev Singh described recognition and tourism as aims. The district initiative also included Lanjia Soura *idital* paintings, a separate tradition.[7]

The accounts describe a programme to promote art, without identifying who painted each wall or chose its design. They do not measure an increase in household income.

A home judged by its residents

Mana's relief and the October 2022 requests for repairs concern different households. Both draw attention to life after construction: whether a roof holds, repairs are affordable and help arrives when needed. A count of completed houses leaves those everyday questions open.

A household needs food as well as shelter. The next part of the story follows the seeds, gardens and harvests that help sustain it.

CHAPTER / 04

Keeping seeds in circulation in Niyamgiri



In Manipadma Jena's July 2015 report, Dasara Kadraka of Kadaraguma described her concern about millet varieties disappearing from local fields. Jena described Dongria Kondh priestesses travelling between villages to obtain seeds for cultivation at home. Finding a seed began with finding someone who still grew it.[1]

A stored seed still needs a grower. Keeping it in use means planting, tending the crop and retaining enough of the harvest for another season.

Finding and sharing

Jena described priestesses, known as *bejuni*, visiting a village where a sought-after variety survived. Seeds brought home were divided among five families. After harvest, recipients repaid the seed in grain at twice the quantity received, according to Jena's account. Members of the neighbouring Dom community carried news about where seeds could be found. Jena also describes priestesses asking about varieties at weekly markets and village gatherings: the search depended on conversation as well as travel.[1]

The 2015 report located sought-after seeds in two villages: *khidi janha*, described as related to sorghum, in Jangojodi, and *kanga-arka*, described as a form of foxtail millet, in Sagadi.[1] These are reported local crop names, rather than botanically verified identities.

Jena describes a particular exchange arrangement in 2015, rather than a rule for every village.

Keeping a collection alive

In Abhijit Mohanty's 2017 reporting, Ghana Majhi, identified as a Dongria farmer from Sindhbahal, recalled his family growing twelve millet varieties. Raibari Sisaka, whose village the report does not specify, described retaining part of the harvest for seed and exchanging seeds with neighbouring farmers.[2]

In Sonali Prasad's December 2018 Mongabay account, Gatri Kadraka of Rodango displayed seeds of millets, pulses and vegetables.[3]

Prasad also described families in Hundijali retaining seed for future planting and helping households that lacked it. Her account of Bijun Parab describes women cleaning seed and making baskets before bringing it to a priestess. Kumtadi Sikoka of Hundijali explained the prayer as seeking the deities' favour before sowing.[3]

Prasad's photograph caption names three people from Hundijali: farmer Drambu Jakesika, priestess Kumtadi Sikoka and messenger Sanyasi Takri. Keeping those names beside their roles makes visible the different work involved in cultivation, ritual and carrying news.[3]

Seeds across cultivation years

Roland Hardenberg's account, based on intensive fieldwork in 2001–03, describes pulses being planted in a plot's first cultivation year and millets in the following year. He places sowing around the monsoon rains, followed by weeding and crop protection, with harvests running from October or November into January.[4] Seed needs followed the cultivation sequence and the rains. This historical account does not establish a current calendar for every village.

When cultivation contracts

Seed saving also depends on space in the fields. In Deepanwita Gita Niyogi's November 2022 reporting, Wane Jakesika of Gandili described a shortage of seeds alongside the reduction in millet cultivation. In the same village, Singari Jakesika explained that her household had shifted land towards horticultural crops to earn more money.[5]

Having seed available and choosing to plant it are connected decisions. The earlier accounts of exchange and revival can coexist with later shortages: they concern different households and years, not a measured trend across Niyamgiri.

Making room for another crop

A collection kept for planting and a field given to another crop can exist in the same landscape. These accounts do not establish a current variety count. They show why keeping seed requires continuing relationships: someone must know where it can be found, someone must share it, and someone must make room to plant it.

CHAPTER / 05

Forest foods and home gardens in Rayagada



For Padmavati Paleka of Leling Padar, the rainy season brought mushrooms, tender bamboo shoots, fruits and leaves. Her account in Basudev Mahapatra's 2017 reporting follows Rayagada's food through the changing year: what becomes available and what reaches the household.[1]

These regional accounts concern several communities, not exclusively Dongria Kondh. They follow food gathered in forests, grown in gardens and bought for meals, along with the work and choices connecting those sources.

The changing seasonal plate

In Abhijit Mohanty's November 2025 reporting, Sana Kumruka of Balipadara recalled varied rainy-season meals, followed by simpler food in summer and winter. She described eating *pokhalo*, fermented rice, with mashed potatoes or a small selection of boiled vegetables. After establishing a garden, she said, the accompanying foods became more varied, including greens, lentils and tubers. She also described her children enjoying the more colourful meals.[3]

Kumruka and Paleka spoke from different villages and reporting periods. Their accounts show why a list of local ingredients is incomplete without seasons, quantities and the work needed to bring food home.

What comes home from the forest

Ecologist Debal Deb's 2017 report for Living Farms examined four forest areas in Rayagada and Balangir. Field assistants visited households and weighed collected foods, including fruits, mushrooms, tubers, flowers and leafy vegetables. Weighing food brought home captured a harvest that might never pass through a market.[2]

The report related forest condition to the diversity and quantity of foods collected. Its comparisons suggested advantages at the sites under informal community management, while acknowledging that the small sample and limited forest types could not establish a universal result.[2]

Food gathered for a household's own meals may never appear in a sales record. The study's household measurements make some of that contribution visible, while the women's accounts explain how it changes their meals.

Learning beside someone who knows

In Abhijit Mohanty's August 2026 reporting, Madhabi Jani of Siriguda in Rayagada described continuing to accompany her mother when gathering mushrooms. Her mother noticed signs in the forest that she did not yet recognise. She said she continued following her mother because she worried about making a mistake. Repeated trips had not made her feel equally skilled.[4]

The report also follows Sabani Majhi, a Paroja woman in Rayagada, on a seasonal gathering trip.[4] Neither account establishes a practice shared by all Dongria households.

Researchers also depended on people who could name and explain what they gathered. A SCSTRTI-commissioned study including Dongria communities describes local workers helping translate plant names into Odia, and summer and monsoon foods known through participants' accounts because fieldwork took place in winter. Those names and recollections provide context; they do not by themselves establish a plant's identity.[5]

Growing food close to home

Mohanty's November 2025 report describes women growing vegetables, pulses and tubers in gardens supported by Living Farms. Rua Kutruka of Balipadara said spending less on vegetables had allowed her family to buy eggs, fish and chicken more often. Her account shows how home cultivation can change purchases as well as what is harvested.[3]

Paleka's seasonal foods, Jani's learning trips and Kutruka's household purchases bring different parts of the food story together. Feeding a family involves deciding what to gather, grow, keep and buy—and adapting those choices as the season changes.

What a household keeps for meals and what it sells lead to different decisions. The market accounts that follow turn to the work between harvest and payment.

CHAPTER / 06

From Niyamgiri harvests to market



Posed market-visit photograph; people pictured are not identified as those discussed.

Telo Wadaka of Khajuri sold bananas, yams and pineapples at the weekly market in Chatikona, according to Deepanwita Gita Niyogi's November 2022 reporting. Her journey from farm to market connects two parts of earning a living: growing produce and finding someone to buy it.[1]

Growers also describe the time spent selling, the effects of losing a buyer and the changes they wanted closer to home.

A long selling day

In July 2017, Bikash Khemka reported growers' frustration despite a plentiful pineapple harvest. Pula Majhi described leaving home early and returning in the evening after selling her fruit. Nabaghana Badaka of Khambesi pointed to the lack of cold storage and wanted a nearby juice factory. The report traced truckloads from a yard near Chatikona railway station to Raipur.[2]

Selling during the pandemic

In Abhijit Mohanty's June 2020 reporting, Sindhe Wadaka of Khajuri said her household had collected harada and bahada but found no buyers. She described both routes closing: traders no longer came to her village, and she could not take produce to the foothills to sell it. Shyam Wadaka described stocks of siyali leaves and seeds, harada, bahada and amla that he could not sell; he said access to Chatikana market was also blocked.[3]



Women photographed during Pillai Sree Vidya's visit to the Dongria region.

Satyanarayan Patnaik's August 2021 report described a different arrangement during pandemic restrictions on train movements. Traders were travelling to growers rather than relying on farmers bringing fruit down to Chatikona. Programme manager Sudarshan Padhi said this saved growers transport costs.[4]

These contrasting experiences concern different crops and households. Buyers coming to a farm could shorten the selling journey. These reports do not establish a wider recovery in growers' earnings.

What growers wanted from processing

Processing also appeared in later official plans. In July 2021, *The New Indian Express* reported an expected opening for a unit at Chatikana. DKDA manager Sudarshan Padhy described direct purchasing from growers and Dongria self-help groups making and packaging products through ORMAS. These were plans, not records of completed sales or jobs.[6]

A September 2026 Pioneer feature returned to the question of processing. Sindhe Wadaka and Pulmi Wadaka said unreliable machinery and insufficient capacity at the Chatikona unit left them dependent on outside traders. Shasil of Khambasi explained his choice to sell to traders rather than let available fruit go to waste; Uma Sankar wanted cold storage for excess fruit.[5]

The women's complaints return attention to whether the machinery served their needs. The reports do not establish the unit's commissioning date, throughput or repair history.

What the seller takes home

Pula Majhi's long selling day, the unsold forest produce and the later complaints about machinery show how much happens between harvest and payment. A sale price alone leaves out travel costs, time and produce that finds no buyer. For a grower, access to a market means both reaching a customer and bringing home a return worth the journey.

Markets also appear in the accounts of Kapadaganda makers, who describe buying cloth and thread. Following those materials brings another kind of work into view.

CHAPTER / 07

Kapadaganda — the embroidered cloth of Niyamgiri



Kumri Sikoka began learning embroidery at about nine or ten, taught by her father's sister. Speaking to Kanak Rajadhyaksha in November 2017, she placed the skill within a family relationship. Other women also credited their *atta*, a paternal aunt.[1]

A Kapadaganda connects several kinds of work: weaving the cotton, embroidering its surface, and choosing how to wear or give it. "It is our identity," Sindhe Wadakka of Khajuri told Annapurna Devi Pandey in an account published in April 2026. She related the joining of coloured threads to Kondh people coming together.[9]

Learning, making and giving

Rajadhyaksha's interviews follow embroidery alongside farming and household work. Binjo Jakesika and Sukri Kadraka fitted stitching into the time available; long training sessions could cause discomfort. Site Jakesika valued the independence that selling her work could bring.[1]

The companion account describes wraps made for oneself, relatives or lovers, and worn at weddings and festivals. People could wrap and drape them in several ways. Not every woman embroidered: the account records choices about whether to do this work as well as how it was done.[2]

Binjo described wearing her own embroidery for celebrations until the cloth tore, then making another. Site sometimes preferred buying gifts because embroidery took so much work.[1]

Making a cloth for someone and making one for sale could involve the same skill, but different relationships. In the 2017 interviews, Kumri reported selling two shawls for ₹2,000 each. At the DKDA training centre, women received ₹100 a day, lunch and materials; Binjo and Site did not know the eventual selling price of that work. These were different historical payment arrangements, not current rates or measures of profit.[1]

The cloth beneath the stitches

The embroiderer's work begins with someone else's weaving. In July 2019, *The New Indian Express* followed Ram Hial in Jhigidi, where he had learned to weave from his father, Kamala Hial. The report described him as the village's remaining maker of Kapadaganda base cloth. When officials brought replacement cloth from Mayurbhanj, embroiderers said it did not match his fabric.[3]

Textile researcher Pankaja Sethi describes unbleached cotton, loosely woven with paired warp and weft yarns in a construction resembling basket weave. She traces its traditional production to neighbouring Dom weavers. The open structure lets women count fabric threads as they position their embroidery.[5]

Preparing those yarns also takes work. Twinkle Rastogi's fieldwork paper, published in January 2023, describes cotton warp dipped in maida flour and water, squeezed and stretched to dry. This sizing strengthens the yarn and helps prevent tangling and breakage. Her account names Hiyal Rama of Jigidi; it does not establish whether he is the Ram Hial named in the earlier report.[17]

In the 2017 interviews, Sukri recalled exchanging fruit for base cloth, followed by buying it with money at markets.[1] Kala Bhoomi's raw-cloth catalogue records harvested crops exchanged for cloth supplied by Domb weavers. The entry gives neither a transaction date nor quantities, leaving the continuation of that arrangement uncertain.[5]

Working a pattern, explaining its meaning

Rajadhyaksha describes embroidery proceeding row by row in satin stitch. Women straighten the worked cloth and trim loose ends with a *katri*, a blade-shaped hair ornament. They buy coloured thread at weekly markets; Ritu Sethi's 2022 UNESCO survey also describes a shift towards purchased thread.[2,18]

In Rajadhyaksha's interviews, *linga*, a triangular motif, represented the mountains and Niyam Raja. *Kairi*, diagonal lines, referred to cultivated fields; *akka*, larger triangles, to leaves; and *kanaka*, a circular motif, to eyes. The women's designs varied in size and arrangement.[2]

Sumita Wadaka of Khambeshi used the terms *Kudi Linga* for triangle designs and *Keri* for lines in Deepanwita Gita Niyogi's January 2026 reporting, connecting them with Niyamgiri's history.[8] Keeping the speaker beside the explanation allows those differences to remain visible.

Colours in cloth and language

Red, yellow and green recur alongside threads described as brown or maroon. The explanations connect embroidery with cultivation, worship and community life.[2,5,11]

Colour	Attributed meanings
Red and maroon	Pankaja Sethi associates them with blood sacrifice.[5]
Green	Sethi relates it to the forest; the GI description also names soil fertility and mountain biodiversity.[5,11]
Yellow	Sethi associates it with turmeric; the GI description adds reciprocal help, harmony and community well-being.[5,11]
Dark brown	Rajadhyaksha's interview account connects it to cultivated soil in the mountain motif.[2]

Colour words vary between accounts. The GI description gives *Kambita*, *Hinga* and *Sanja* for red, yellow and green. Rajadhyaksha records *netru*, *hinga* and *kadi* alongside red, yellow and dark brown. Sanghamitra Sethi and Paramananda Naik's study of 40 women and girls in Kurli gram panchayat records *Kambiti*, *Aka*, *Hinga* and *Mirga* for red, green, yellow and brown.[2,11,13] The sources do not resolve the differences in wording.

The 2018 *Odia–Kuvi Sabdakosh* adds another connection: its blood entry includes ରକତ, while turmeric is ହିଙ୍ଗା and yellow is ହିଙ୍ଗାରାଙ୍ଗୁ.[12] These entries help explain relationships between words and substances; they do not establish a dye recipe. Sethi treats earlier natural dyes as probable, while the GI description asserts forest-derived colours without a dated recipe or material test in the inspected passages. A yellow thread's association with turmeric does not show what dyed it.[5,11]

Recognition and what reaches the maker

In August 2026, embroiderer and former Kurli sarpanch Dinja Jakesika described greater demand and recognition, while questioning how much retail benefit reached the women. She also described training to apply Kapadaganda motifs to garments, bags, notebooks and other products.[6]

Formal recognition and public support took several forms. Kapadaganda's GI certificate is dated 2 January 2024; its application names the Niyamgiri Dongoria Kandho Weavers Association and SCSTRTI.[4] A parliamentary reply records toolkits distributed to 20 artisans, while AdiShilpi records describe designer recruitment and plans for training, materials and honoraria. These documents establish particular kinds of support, not subsequent earnings.[10,14,16]

Reliable cloth remained a concern. Diana Sahu's August 2026 reporting said Jhigidi's weavers had stopped producing the fabric. Officials proposed a local weaving cluster, with Koraput cloth as a fallback. The report named Lahari Kundika, Murudi Wadaka and Bangari Wadaka of Khambesi as selected trainers. That selection recognised expertise within the community; completed training, cluster production and deliveries were not established.[7]

New markets raise Dinja's question again. RISA promoted Dongria embroidery and Kotpad cotton as distinct traditions.[15] Boito's "Dongria Overlay" description does not name its embroiderer or payment. A related profile's prompt-payment testimony comes from Kotpad weaver Jagabandhu Panika, not a Dongria embroiderer.[19] Folkweave's Kapadaganda work appears among several regional textile traditions, and SPREAD's reported exhibition sales combine several crafts; that total cannot identify an individual embroiderer's return.[20,21]

Kumri's learning, Ram Hial's cloth and Dinja's question about payment belong to different moments in this history. Together they keep attention on the relationships that make the finished wrap possible: someone teaches, someone weaves, someone stitches, and someone wears or buys the work.



CHAPTER / 08

Dongria ornaments in use



A requested group portrait of children preparing for a wedding, according to the photographer.

As women stitched Kapadaganda, a hair ornament served as a cutting tool. Kanak Rajadhyaksha's account, based on November 2017 interviews, describes them using a blade-shaped *katri* to cut thread into manageable lengths and trim loose ends.[1]

In the embroiderer's hands, the katri has work to do. Its appearance alone might not explain that use.

From households to markets

Sanghamitra Sethi and Paramananda Naik's Jhigidi study follows Ghasi households making ornaments and other metal objects. Older relatives watched over moulds drying outside, while women gathered soil and prepared wax and moulds. Children helped their parents and learned through that participation. Both husbands and wives sold work at weekly markets, including Chatikana. Sales could involve cash or exchanges for produce.[5]

The authors also describe Ghasi manufacture of brass handles for the *katri* worn in Dongria women's hair. The tool used while embroidering therefore connects another household's metalwork with the making of cloth.[5]

The study's historical account also describes travelling sellers receiving food and a place to stay in Dongria settlements. Metalwork moved through relationships of hospitality as well as purchase and exchange. These descriptions are not verified current arrangements.[5]

Makers and wearers

The Odisha State Tribal Museum's 2019 catalogue describes *andu*, brass anklets associated with Dongria Kandha women, as elliptical objects with raised edges and embossed decoration. It attributes their manufacture to non-tribal artisans. The same catalogue lists coin necklaces under the name *Takamecodica*.[4]

Mohanty and Sahoo describe Dongria contributions to designs and manufacture by neighbouring artisans, particularly Ghasi craftspeople. Their account connects wearers and makers across communities, without naming the people behind a particular commission.[3]

A knife in the museum

Kala Bhoomi Odisha Crafts Museum holds an object catalogued as *Mila Katri*. The Virtual Museum of Images and Sounds describes it as a small, portable knife for cutting thread. Its acquisition record traces it through the General Manager of the Regional Industries Centre, Rayagada, to Nakul Pidikaka.[2]

The collection was documented in 2019–20, but the knife is undated and its maker unnamed. Nakul Pidikaka's place in the acquisition record does not establish that he made it; nor does the Ghasi household study identify the maker of this particular object.[2,5]

Hairpins and their names

G. N. Mohanty and T. Sahoo's 2006 account distinguishes several hair ornaments. A museum-derived table lists *Aska* as a hairpin or small knife and *Sipna* as a separate hairpin. The accompanying prose calls a small knife worn in the hair *mila katra*.[3]

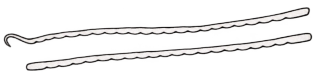
The table distinguishes the names. Whether a wearer uses them in the same way needs a wearer's explanation.

What a wearer can tell us

The knife that trims an embroidery thread, the patterned anklet and the coin necklace invite different questions. Who made this piece? How was it acquired? When is it worn, and what does its owner value about it?

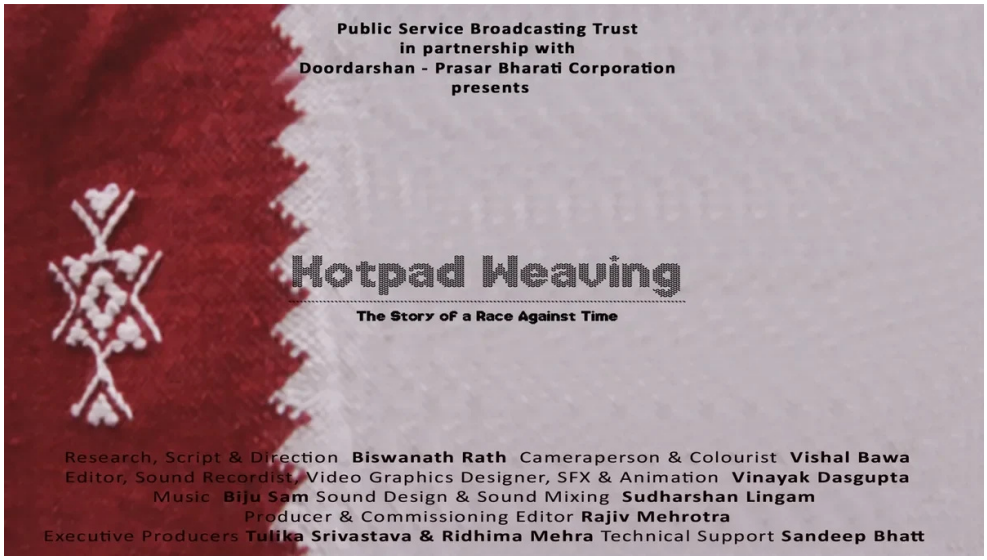
Appearance alone cannot answer these questions or reliably establish someone's age, marital status or beliefs. A catalogue can record an object's name and acquisition; its wearer can explain how it fits into a life.

The relationships between wearers and neighbouring craftspeople continue in the next comparison, which follows the distinct work of Jhigidi and Kotpad textile makers.



CHAPTER / 09

Kotpad and Kapadaganda through their makers



Ram Hial learned weaving from his father in Jhigidi. Kapilo Mahanta's profile places her work in Kotpad's Mirgan Street. Following these two practitioners helps distinguish cloth woven as a ground for Dongria embroidery from yarn dyed and patterned at the Kotpad loom.[1,3]

The cloth from Jhigidi

In July 2019, *The New Indian Express* traced Kapadaganda's coarse base cloth to Domb weaving families in Jhigidi, in Rayagada's Bissamcuttack block. Its report named Ram Hial's father and teacher, Kamala Hial. Ram Hial described demanding work and low returns as reasons younger people were reluctant to continue.[1]

The report also recorded an attempt to obtain replacement cloth from Mayurbhanj. Dongria women said it did not match Hial's fabric. Their response suggests that the base cloth mattered to how the embroidery was made and valued.[1]

Kanak Rajadhyaksha's Sahapedia account, based on November 2017 interviews, follows the next stage: women purchasing cloth and coloured thread at weekly markets, cutting thread into manageable lengths and embroidering successive rows in satin stitch. Women worked when they had time; the account explicitly notes that not every woman embroidered.[2]

The work of colour in Kotpad

NIFT's September 2026 profile credits Kapilo Mahanta with more than 35 years of textile experience, placing her in Kotpad's Mirgan Street. Alongside her profile, its general craft description follows cotton yarn through washing and dyeing before it reaches the pit loom. Aal roots feature among the dyeing materials; the resulting palette includes reddish-maroon, brown and black alongside undyed tones.[3]

Patterns are also made at the loom, including supplementary-weft motifs. NIFT identifies the Mirgan community with this tradition and names Dhurua, Poroja, Gadaba, Madhia, Bhatara and Muria among communities for whom Kotpad textiles were traditionally made.[3]

Comparing the making processes

The Jhigidi report identifies a base-cloth weaver and the embroiderers who valued his fabric. NIFT's Kotpad account follows dyeing and weaving within a different craft tradition. Neither account makes the two production histories interchangeable.

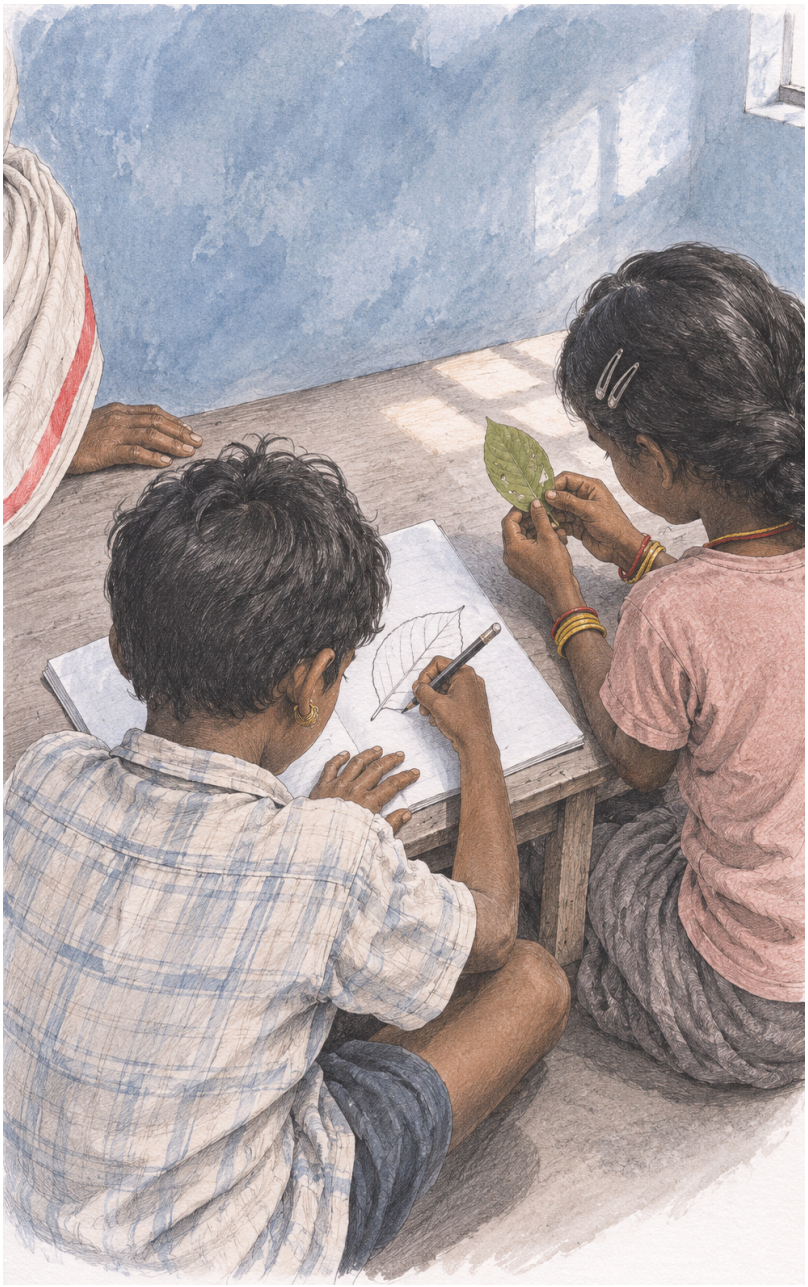
Colour needs the same care. Sahapedia's interview account describes purchased embroidery thread; NIFT documents Kotpad yarn dyeing. A red area on each textile does not, by itself, establish the same colouring material or technique.[2,3]

Dongria embroidery and Kotpad cotton also shared a promotional platform: RISA's 2026 launch and New Delhi store presented them as separate traditions.[4] That connection documents joint promotion. The cloth supplied for Dongria embroidery in the account here came from Jhigidi; these sources do not establish a supply relationship with Kotpad weavers.

Ram Hial learned weaving from his father; embroiderers describe learning from their aunts. Alongside the work of supplying cloth, preparing colour and forming patterns runs the work of passing on knowledge. The next chapters turn to students, teachers and the languages through which they learn.

CHAPTER / 10

Learning and belonging in Niyamgiri



Mukteswar Wadaka taught children in Khambesi without charging for tuition during the pandemic lockdown. In Abhijit Mohanty's January 2021 report, the Dongria Kondh student also spoke of wanting to enter the civil service and challenge assumptions about the work Adivasi people could do.[1]

Mukteswar brought teaching close to home. For students who left Niyamgiri to study, education also raised questions about language, family and belonging.

Ambition and example

Mohanty's report followed students associated with the Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences in Bhubaneswar. Phulaki Wadaka, who had earned a master's degree in psychology, described wanting to encourage friends to continue their studies. Ravindra Wadaka recalled taking up weightlifting after encouragement from coach Shubakanta Malya. At his first competition he felt nervous among so many people, despite months of training.[1]

Understanding the lesson

In September 2012, journalist Manipadma Jena reported from Sikhsya Niketan, a residential school for Dongria Kondh girls in the Chatikona area. Teacher Jayanti Sabar described students helping translate lessons into Kuvi for classmates who struggled with the language of instruction. Understanding a lesson depended partly on classmates who could explain it in familiar words.[2]

The same report introduced Rina Wadaka of Khambesi, then a schoolgirl who wanted to teach. Jena traced her inspiration to Kasturi Melaka, who had completed school.[2] Another student's example helped Rina imagine teaching others; the report does not tell us what career she later pursued.

Readers, primers and workbooks

One resource for Kuvi readers is *Pilanka Katha (Kuvi), Part I*, published by Odisha's Academy of Tribal Languages and Culture. Its preparation credits name a Kuvi Resource Group: Trinath Wadaka, Tripati Hikaka and Surya Narayan Padhy, with Paramananda Patel as coordinator and Priyaranjan Baral as illustrator. One story page places Kuvi text above an illustration and an Odia passage below it, using Odia-based writing.[3]

The reader's edition date remains unconfirmed. A separate resource, NCERT's *Kuwi Primer*, was launched in August 2023; a 2025 CIET newsletter records revised Kuwi and Desia primers submitted for printing.[4]

By March 2026, the Ministry of Education also reported the development of *Shishu Vatika* workbooks in Odia script for languages including Kuvi.[5] Readers, primers and workbooks offer different resources. These publication records do not tell us which edition reached a particular Dongria classroom or how a teacher used it.

Staying connected to home

A July 2016 Kalpavriksh study recorded parents' interest in literacy and education alongside concerns about sending children away. Participants wanted schools within Niyamgiri, teaching that related to local life, and teachers who understood the community. Their concerns included children's separation from parents and from the knowledge associated with livelihoods in the hills.[6]

The study drew on short visits and translated discussions, with limited participation by women and young people.[6] The parents' concerns and students' aspirations raise connected questions: where to study, which language to learn through and how to remain close to family.

Returning to education

SPREAD's 2024–25 annual report describes Dasami Wadaka, an embroiderer from Khajur and member of its Rang Kerang collective, returning to senior-secondary study through the National Institute of Open Schooling. According to the account, she stayed at SPREAD's Koraput office while attending her examinations. Her friend Jyoti Huika, whom the report identifies as Dongria Kondh, accompanied her and also decided to resume her education.[7]

The account leaves the examination dates and results unstated. It describes a return to studying, not a completed qualification.

Teaching close to home

Mukteswar's village tuition, Sabar's pupils explaining lessons and the two women returning to study show different forms of help between learners. Qualifications and careers matter in these accounts, but so do familiar words, someone willing to explain, and company when a person begins again.

CHAPTER / 11

Kuvi and the Jatapu script



A lesson becomes useful when a learner can make sense of it. In Learning and belonging, Jayanti Sabar's pupils helped classmates by explaining lessons in Kuvi.[1]

Three distinct resources matter here: the *Kuwi Primer*, written with Odia-based letters; the *Jatapu (Kuvi) Primer*, which uses Telugu-based writing; and a separate Jatapu script devised by Prasanna Sree. Her alphabet is not the one used in the Jatapu primer.[3,5,6]

Kuvi and Kui

The Central Institute of Indian Languages identifies Kuvi as a Dravidian language spoken in Odisha and Andhra Pradesh and records its use of the Odia script. CIIL maintains a separate entry for Kui, describing it as closely related to Kuvi. The names are not interchangeable.[2]

A familiar script can help a reader recognise letters without making the language itself familiar.

A name heard in Niyamgiri

In *Children of the Earth Goddess*, Roland Hardenberg records **Kuang Kata** as the Dongria name for their language. He also names two people who taught him: Brundabati Kondapani and Sandyarani Kadraka, workers in a local development organisation. His acknowledgement makes visible the people whose teaching helped an ethnographer listen and understand.[13]

The spelling follows his account; Hardenberg explains that he recorded words as he heard them, rather than using a linguist's transcription. Glottolog separately catalogues **Dongria Kuvi** as a dialect. Neither a catalogue label nor a printed spelling replaces the way a speaker names and pronounces their own language.[13,14]

A teacher making resources

A regional example comes from Putsil in Koraput. A November 2020 account by government and programme staff describes anganwadi worker Phulamani Jani noticing that children engaged more readily when she spoke Kuvi. Yet she wondered whether Odia would better prepare them for primary school; some community members shared that concern. After training in 2017, she combined purchased learning materials with ones she made locally and composed Kuvi songs.[11]

Her account brings a teacher's choice into view: how to build on children's understanding while preparing them for school. It does not identify the writing system of her materials or describe the community as Dongria.

The Odia-based Kuwi primer

The *Kuwi Primer* was prepared in an NCERT workshop with the Central University of Odisha, Koraput, according to its credits. Its alphabet chart and illustrated lessons use Odia-based writing.[3]

The Ministry of Education records its launch alongside the Desia primer in Bhubaneswar on 17 August 2023. The intended audience was children speaking these languages in undivided Koraput.[4]

A 2025 CIET newsletter later records revised Desia and Kuwi primers submitted for printing, without confirming printing or identifying recipient schools.[12]

The Telugu-based Jatapu primer

The CIIL–NCERT *Jatapu (Kuvi) Primer* has a first-edition date of 9 March 2024. It is intended for early learners at Balvatika and Anganwadi levels and for adult literacy programmes. Its alphabet chart and opening illustrated lesson use Telugu-based writing. Its resource-person credits include headmaster Tadangi Timmarusu and teacher Puvvala Ramaswamy, both working in Parvathipuram Manyam district, Andhra Pradesh.[5]

Jatapu (Kuvi) is the publication's title, not a name for every Kuvi-speaking community.

Prasanna Sree's Jatapu script

Prasanna Sree's university-hosted academic profile lists Jhatapu among the languages for which she devised scripts.[6] The Atlas of Endangered Alphabets explains the design through a palm-leaf parasol, with a curved upper portion and a supporting vertical shaft.[7]

Omniglot publishes a chart and credits Prasanna Sree as its information provider. It displays 13 vowel-labelled and 19 consonant-labelled entries, with additional panels called “Independent vowels” and “Long consonants.”[8] The labels describe the chart, not a verified inventory of Kuvi sounds; “Long consonants” remains unexplained in the materials examined.

These sources document Prasanna Sree’s design. They do not establish that Dongria villages use it, or that it is an ancestral writing system.

Listening beyond the alphabet

Linguistic descriptions record speech sounds as well as written forms. PHOIBLE’s Kuvi sound inventory, drawing on Israel’s 1979 grammar, includes short and long vowels, such as /i/ and /iː/, and nasalised vowels such as /ĩ/.[9] These symbols describe pronunciation, not letters in the devised Jatapu script.

Behind a grammar are people who help a researcher hear and understand. In the reproduced preface to his grammar, Israel credits Binondo K. Manding of Narengpodra and contributors including Prokas Meleka and Anondo Meleka of Putisil. He dates his fieldwork to 1971–74, with further examination through 1977, mainly in Saptamaha near Putisil and Narengpodra on Deomali.[10]

PHOIBLE presents particular documented sound inventories, not every speaker's pronunciation.[9] This regional description cannot by itself map the devised Jatapu signs to spoken Kuvi in Niyamgiri; that needs examples and explanations from speakers.

Words across regions, voices in an archive

The *Kuvi Dictionary* app offers another route into the language. Its publisher describes a collaborative multilingual-education project initiated by the Education Department through ITDAs, with Telugu, English and Hindi indexes. It covers Kuvi spoken in Andhra Pradesh and is described as a community-approved draft. It can help a reader compare words, but entries need checking with Dongria speakers before becoming a Niyamgiri glossary.[15]

Elsewhere in Odisha's language-documentation network, O Foundation's OpenSpeaks lists Opino Gomango's work with Sora, Juray, Juang and Gorum. Its community documenters record speakers on audio and video; its tools support subtitles, descriptive information and consent agreements. This is a useful example of how voices can accompany written accounts, not evidence of an OpenSpeaks Dongria Kuvi collection.[16]

A small collection shaped by Dongria speakers could begin with words they choose: a place name, a seed, an everyday greeting. The recording, explanation and translation would belong together, with each speaker deciding what may be shared.

From letters to lessons

Publication and classroom use are separate milestones. Neither primer's publication record identifies the edition used in a particular Dongria school.

Sabar's pupils explained lessons to classmates; Phulamani made resources for children she taught. Their accounts return attention to who can understand and use the words. The song accounts that follow introduce other people who explain, remember and pass them on.

CHAPTER / 12

Songs and singers in Dongria life



Public dance performance; not an identified singer or song.

Older women held important oral knowledge in Priyadarshini Mishra's fieldwork account, published in *Lokaratna* in 2018. She described Dongria singers mentoring younger people. Singers and ritual specialists also helped her record songs and stories, then translate and explain them in Odia and English.[1]

Learning songs and their occasions

Mishra named Sinde Wadaka of Kurli, teacher Laxman Hikaka and Siba Kadrka of Mundabali among those who helped her preliminary research. She also recorded a return visit during 5–14 December 2018. Her discussion distinguished entertainment songs, songs associated with birth, marriage and death, and ritual songs.[1]

To listen is also to ask who is singing, whom they address and what has brought people together.

Dambu Praska and remembered voices

A Living Farms account published by GRAIN in July 2009 identifies Dambu Praska as a Dongria Kondh bard. It describes him accompanying a story of Niyam Raja on an instrument made from a gourd, and links footage under the title *The Lament of Niyam Raja*. The song, as presented in Living Farms' English rendering, moves from food and the mountain's gifts to fear for its future. The translator is not credited, and the original recording has not been checked here. The account dates from July 2009; the performance is undated.[4]

In a statement published by *Round Table India* in August 2018, students identifying themselves as from Niyamgiri said Video Republic's videos helped them know and remember the late Dambu Praska.[5]

An album and its credits

A different setting appears in Debabrata Mohanty's October 2010 report on the album *Niyamgiri ti Rani*. He credited Manmath Mishra with its music, Gopal Melaka with its lyrics, and Jitu Jakasika, Ramesh Kulesika, Gopal Melaka, Stephen and Biraji with singing. The report also identified Vedanta Alumina's involvement in the launch.[2]

The launch reports label the album's language as Kui, an identification not checked here against the recordings or with speakers. Participation in the album does not establish the singers' political views or a community position.

Composer Manmath Mishra described combining modern instruments with *Nishan* and *Mohuri* for popular appeal, according to a separate launch report in *The New Indian Express*.[3] These are his reported instrument names.

From recording to film

CircaFilms' own Vimeo description identifies Dambu Praska as the singer behind its stop-motion film *The Song of Niyamagiri*, and credits Surya Shankar Dash with the original recording. Artwork is credited to thebathroompainter, title design to Montry Manuel, and writing, editing and direction to Nirvikalpa.[6]

A separate Culture Unplugged entry for *The Lament of Niyamraja* credits Dash as director and producer of a 13-minute film. It lists 2007 under "Focus Years," which does not establish an exact performance date.[7] The credits distinguish singer, recorder and filmmakers, but do not establish whether both films use the same recorded take.

Kriti Film Club recalls screening Dash's film in September 2009 and recommended it again in June 2020.[8] Its screening history records another way audiences encountered his work, without establishing the performance date or the film's premiere.

Listening with context

Mishra learned with the help of singers and interpreters. For the students who wrote about Dambu Praska, a recording was also a way of remembering a person. These encounters ask us to keep a voice connected to a person, a language and an occasion. The singer's name matters as much as the song's journey.

Looking again

I began with a shawl. The reading brought me to people whose names I now want to remember.

Site Jakesika's embroidery, Mukteswar Wadaka's teaching and the work of keeping seeds in circulation belong to different lives. Bringing them into one book does not make those lives the same. Each asks for its own attention.

The cloth that first delighted me still does. But I look at it differently now. Alongside colour and pattern, I think about time: the hours spent making, the work fitted around other work, and the knowledge passed between people. Beauty has become a reason to pay closer attention.

There is much more to learn. I hope to keep asking, listening and revising what I think I know.

If this book leaves you curious, I hope you follow that curiosity towards the people and their work. Remember a name. Look again at a familiar object. Ask where it came from and how it was made.

I bought a shawl that evening. I am still learning how much there is to see in it.

Words in this book

These short definitions explain how the terms are used in this book. Personal and place-name spellings follow the cited accounts and may vary.

Aal
The roots used as a dye material in NIFT's account of Kotpad yarn colouring. *Chapter 9.*

Bejuni
A priestess; the seed accounts describe particular bejuni helping recover varieties and conducting rituals before sowing. *Chapter 4.*

Bijun Parab
A seed festival described in the 2018 reporting, with seeds prepared and brought to a priestess before planting. *Chapter 4.*

DKDA
Dongria Kondh Development Agency; the development agency referred to in the training and livelihood accounts. *Chapter 7.*

GI
Geographical indication: an indication linking goods to a place whose origin gives them a particular quality, reputation or other characteristic. *Chapter 7.*

Gram Sabha
A village assembly. In the Niyamgiri case, the assemblies examined community, cultural and religious claims connected with the proposed mining. *Chapter 2.*

Words in this book

Jatapu
Used here in the title Jatapu (Kuvi) Primer and for Prasanna Sree's devised script. The primer uses Telugu-based writing, not that devised script. *Chapter 11.*

Kapadaganda
Cloth embroidered by Dongria makers, worn and given as well as made for sale; sources also spell it Kapdagonda or Kapdaganda. *Chapter 7.*

Katri
A blade-shaped hair ornament also used to cut thread and trim loose ends in the embroidery account. *Chapter 8.*

Kotpad
A town in Koraput district and the name associated here with its cotton dyeing and handloom-weaving tradition, distinct from Kapadaganda embroidery. *Chapter 9.*

Kui
A Dravidian language closely related to Kuvi, with a separate entry in the Central Institute of Indian Languages collections. *Chapter 11.*

Words in this book

Kuvi
A Dravidian language spoken in Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Its name is not interchangeable with Kui; Kuwi is a spelling used in one primer's title. *Chapter 11.*

NIFT
National Institute of Fashion Technology, publisher of the Kapilo Mahanta craft profile used in the Kotpad chapter. *Chapter 9.*

Niyam Raja
The deity associated with the Niyamgiri hills in the worship, seed and song accounts. *Chapter 12.*

ORMAS
Odisha Rural Development and Marketing Society, the state organisation referred to in the account of product marketing plans. *Chapter 6.*

Pucca
A building whose walls and roof use durable materials, such as burnt brick, stone, cement or concrete. *Chapter 3.*

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Dongria life in Niyamgiri

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01. Dongria life in Niyamgiri
Fields and hills photographed during a Niyamgiri visit in 2018.
Pillai Sree Vidya. Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Colour and tone adjusted for print; composition unchanged.

02. Niyamgiri: cultivation and village decisions
Cultivated land in the Niyamgiri landscape, photographed in 2018.
Pillai Sree Vidya. Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Colour and tone adjusted for print; composition unchanged.

03. Homes and the work of repair in Niyamgiri
Timber, earth and grass thatch beneath low eaves - an interpretive architectural detail informed by a 2016 description. It is not a documented building or a universal present-day form.
Illustration: Project Odisha. Housing reference: The Niyamgiri Story: Challenging the Idea of Growth Without Limits?, July 2016, p. 6. Imagined composition; portrait adaptation for this edition.

04. Keeping seeds in circulation in Niyamgiri
Hands tipping seeds from a folded packet into a cupped palm - an interpretive illustration. The exchange is imagined; no seed variety is identified.
Adapted illustration: Project Odisha. CC BY-SA 4.0. Clothing reference: photograph by Pillai Sree Vidya, CC BY-SA 4.0. Imagined composition; portrait adaptation for this edition.

05. Forest foods and home gardens in Rayagada
A woman tending plants, seen from above along a garden path - an interpretive illustration. The garden is imagined, not a botanical identification guide.
Adapted illustration: Project Odisha. CC BY-SA 4.0. Clothing reference: photograph by Pillai Sree Vidya, CC BY-SA 4.0. Imagined composition; portrait adaptation for this edition.

06. From Niyamgiri harvests to market
A posed photograph during a market visit, catalogued as “Dangaria women 02” in 2018. It does not document a particular sale or identify the people discussed in this article.
Pillai Sree Vidya. Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Colour and tone adjusted for print; composition unchanged.

07. Kapadaganda — the embroidered cloth of Niyamgiri
An embroidered wrap across a shoulder and back - an interpretive illustration with imagined cloth folds.
Adapted illustration: Project Odisha, CC BY-SA 4.0. Clothing reference: photograph by Debanutosh, CC BY-SA 4.0. Portrait adaptation for this edition.

Pictures & credits

08. Dongria ornaments in use
A requested group portrait of children preparing for a wedding, according to the photographer.
Shubhamkindia. Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Resized; composition unchanged.

09. Kotpad and Kapadaganda through their makers
Release poster for Kotpad Weaving (2018), directed by Biswanath Rath; not a workshop photograph.
Seven5carrom (Commons contributor). Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Resized; composition unchanged.

10. Learning and belonging in Niyamgiri
Children drawing and observing a leaf indoors - an interpretive illustration. The figures and learning activity are imagined.
Adapted illustration: Project Odisha. CC BY-SA 4.0. Clothing reference: photograph by Pillai Sree Vidya, CC BY-SA 4.0. Imagined composition; portrait adaptation for this edition.

11. Kuvi and the Jatapu script
Two women talking beside a market stall - an interpretive illustration. The figures and conversation are imagined; no speech or script is transcribed.
Adapted illustration: Project Odisha. CC BY-SA 4.0. Clothing reference: photograph by Pillai Sree Vidya, CC BY-SA 4.0. Imagined composition; portrait adaptation for this edition.

12. Songs and singers in Dongria life
Public dance performance identified by the photographer as Dongria Khond, photographed in 2018. This is not an identified song, singer or village ceremony.
Debanutosh. Original photograph / source. CC BY-SA 4.0. Resized; composition unchanged.

Interpretive stitch-band drawing: Project Odisha. Technique reference: Kanak Rajadhyaksha, Kapdagondas: Motifs and Technique, Sahapedia. Hairpin drawing: interpretive adaptation by Project Odisha. Hairpin reference: photograph by Pillai Sree Vidya, CC BY-SA 4.0; hairpin adaptation under the same licence. Drawings simplify details. Author portrait: supplied by Ahimanikya Satapathy.

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A book about the relationships between people, knowledge and place.



Ahimanikya Satapathy

Ahimanikya Satapathy is the founder of Project Odisha, exploring Odisha's places, culture and literature through research and storytelling.